When I started the Computer Science program, I was focused mostly on becoming a stronger software developer. I was especially interested in frontend development and in building applications people could actually use. Over the last several years, both my coursework and my professional experience have changed how I think about my role in technology. I still value the technical side, but I have learned that one of my biggest strengths is being able to connect the technical work back to the business problem. That has shaped my goal of moving into Product Owner roles, where I can use my development background to help translate business needs into work that technical teams can understand and deliver.

The program helped me build confidence in areas beyond simply writing code. I have worked through software design, mobile development, databases, embedded systems, artificial intelligence, user experience, and secure coding concepts. Some of the most useful learning came from having to work through trade-offs instead of looking for one perfect answer. In CS 350, for example, I worked with a Raspberry Pi and had to think about how software interacts with hardware, timing, memory, and device limitations. In other courses, I worked through AI and machine-learning concepts, UI and UX decisions, mobile architecture, and application design. Those experiences gave me a broader view of computer science and made it easier to see how different parts of a system affect one another.

Collaboration and communication have also become a much bigger part of how I see myself professionally. In a team environment, I am comfortable moving between technical conversations and business conversations. I have learned that good development work depends on more than individual coding ability. Teams need clear requirements, shared understanding, feedback, and a way to make decisions when priorities compete. That is something I have also experienced professionally when working with stakeholders, developers, and other teams around requirements, defects, releases, and product decisions. My technical background helps me understand what developers need, while my interest in product ownership pushes me to keep asking whether the work is solving the right problem.

The program also strengthened my understanding of data structures and algorithms. Earlier in my coursework, I tended to think about an algorithm mainly in terms of whether it produced the correct result. Over time, I started paying more attention to how data is organized, how often it is processed, and what trade-offs come with different approaches. That became especially clear in my capstone when I enhanced the Weight Tracker application so it could use historical weight data instead of only the most recent entry. That work required me to think about ordered collections, traversal, edge cases, and

efficiency, but the bigger lesson was that data becomes more useful when the application is designed to actually do something meaningful with it.

Software engineering and database work have probably been the areas where I can most clearly see my growth. I have learned that working code is not always well-structured code, and that maintainability matters once a project starts to grow. Refactoring the Weight Tracker reinforced that point because I had to separate responsibilities that were originally concentrated in one activity. The database enhancement added another layer to that understanding. I moved from simply storing and retrieving records to thinking more carefully about relationships, ownership, migration, password handling, and what the database itself should enforce instead of leaving everything to the application.

Security has also become something I think about much earlier in the development process. Instead of treating security as something added after the feature works, I have learned to look for places where assumptions can create risk. In the Weight Tracker, examples included plain-text password storage, weak ownership checks, and relationships that existed in the application logic but were not enforced by the database. Addressing those issues helped me see security as part of the design itself. That mindset will continue to matter whether I am writing code or working as a Product Owner, because product decisions can introduce security and privacy risks long before implementation begins.

Developing the ePortfolio helped bring those different areas together. It forced me to go back to work I had already completed and evaluate it with more experience than I had when I first created it. That was valuable because the improvements were not just about adding features. I had to explain what was weak, decide what was worth changing, make the enhancement, test it, and then communicate why the change mattered. That process reflects the kind of work I expect to continue doing professionally: understanding an existing system, identifying where it can be improved, and balancing technical decisions with user and business needs.

The artifacts that follow show that progression from three different angles. The first enhancement focuses on software design and engineering by restructuring the Weight Tracker so responsibilities such as validation, goal evaluation, SMS behavior, and data access are more clearly separated. The second focuses on algorithms and data structures by using historical weight records to provide trend analysis instead of relying only on the latest value. The third focuses on databases by improving password storage, relational integrity, ownership checks, date handling, and database upgrades. Together, the artifacts show more than three separate technical skills. They show how software design, algorithms, databases, security, and user needs all influence one another inside the same application.

Completing this program has helped me become more certain about what I want to do next. I am leaving the program with stronger technical skills, but also with a clearer understanding of where I bring the most value. I want to stay close to technology while working more directly with stakeholders, product decisions, requirements, and prioritization. My goal is to move into Product Owner work where I can use my development background as an advantage, especially when helping business and technical teams understand each other and make better decisions.